

COMPETITIVE EVENTS PROGRAM



LEVELS OF COMPETITION

- A. The breakdown of grades noted below is used to designate levels for competition entries. Each level has its own unique competitive events guide.
- Middle School/Junior High School level—Grades 5, 6, 7, 8, 9
 - High School level—Grades 9, 10, 11, 12
 - Ninth graders must compete at the level in which the chapter affiliates.
 - If the configuration of the school includes grades 9-12, ninth grade students must compete in high school events.
 - If the configuration of the school includes grades 6-9 or 7-9, ninth grade students must compete in middle school events.
- B. If the school has a K-12 configuration, or a configuration other than the examples above, national TSA should be contacted for clarification and approval regarding the appropriate school level designation.

GENERAL RULES AND REGULATIONS

NOTE: General rules and regulations apply to *all* competitive events and are *in addition* to each event's specific guidelines.

A. Affiliation and Membership

1. TSA members, advisors, and chapters must be currently affiliated with TSA to enter any competitive event.
2. TSA membership rights extend through the year of graduation.
3. Students who graduate midyear may compete at the national conference that immediately follows their end-of-year graduation.

B. Conference Registration, Attendance, and Participation in Events

1. Individuals who wish to attend the conference must complete conference registration.
2. Students must be registered and be in attendance with an adult chaperone at the National TSA Conference in order to enter and become a semifinalist or finalist in any event.

3. All adult advisors, chaperones, and student participants must be in attendance for the entire conference.
4. National TSA Conference registrants must wear conference identification badges at all times.
5. The TSA competitive event limit is six (6) events per conference participant, individual and team events combined.
6. Team events:
 - a. All team members must be affiliated with the same chapter.
 - b. Registration for any team competitive event requires the identification of all team members. A (one) team captain must be designated by the chapter advisor for any of the events with online submission requirements. The captain is responsible for uploading the competition entry/documentation on behalf of the entire team. Team captain responsibility does not apply for team events that involve a preliminary exam; all team members must take an exam to determine an average team score.
 - c. Unless otherwise designated in a competition's eligibility guideline, the minimum size of a team is two (2) members and the maximum size of a team is six (6) members.

C. Student Responsibilities for Competitions

1. Student members should create their account in the [TSA Student Member Site](#). Affiliated student members may access "member only" resources, including the Student Member Competitive Events Guide, and submit selected competition entries for the national TSA conference.
2. It is the individual responsibility of each participant to obtain all rules and guidelines for competitive events.
3. Lack of knowledge or understanding about a particular event is neither reason nor excuse for an individual to request an accommodating adjustment or change.
4. Students and advisors must routinely check the TSA website, [TSAweb.org](#), for updated information about TSA general rules and competitive event guidelines. One month prior to the conference, no additional updates will be posted to this page.

5. Students who participate in any TSA competitive event are responsible for knowing all updates, changes, and clarifications related to that event.
6. Student competitors are responsible for ensuring that all competition-related websites and internet-based content are accessible from their device (personal or school-issued). TSA assumes no responsibility for a student competitor's inability to access national TSA conference competition platforms and/or web-based content.
7. When a decision is made by a member to compete in an event, it is imperative that the member thoroughly read and understand the rules, regulations, procedures, and evaluation criteria for the chosen event(s). National TSA is responsible for addressing mistakes or discrepancies in the competitive event guides and accomplishes this through competition updates on the TSA website. National TSA is not responsible for interpreting, advising, or suggesting ways that a member might develop a viable response or solution to a competitive event challenge.

D. Competition Entries

1. Entries must be started and completed during the current school year.
2. Entries may be submitted for one (1) year, and one (1) competition only. An infraction of this rule results in disqualification.
3. Each participant/team shall submit only one (1) entry per event.
4. All entries that require a documentation portfolio must be secured in a [clear front report cover](#) unless otherwise indicated in an event's regulations.
5. All entries must be in English.
6. Participants must check in and pick up their event entries at the times and places stated in the conference program, or as announced during the National TSA Conference.

7. If a competition includes a test on-site at the national conference, the test will be administered online only (Wi-Fi service will be provided at no cost only for competitions). Paper tests will not be available unless deemed necessary. Individual participants, or each team member, must bring to the testing site:
 - a. One (1) laptop or tablet (personal or school-issued) capable of networking via Wi-Fi and able to run solely on battery power for up to two (2) consecutive hours. Chrome is the preferred browser.
 - b. Optional: One (1) mouse
8. For any competition that involves the use of a pencil (e.g., for taking a test if necessary, for producing required sketches), participants must provide—and bring to the test site two (2) pencils, either:
 - sharpened standard #2/HB grade with an eraser, or
 - #2 mechanical with an eraser.
9. Entry content:
 - a. National TSA provides guidelines for individual and team entry content but does not bear responsibility for content choices made by participants.
 - b. Entries are evaluated on the basis of an event's official rating form.
10. Projects and/or products:
 - a. Unless otherwise specified, no identifying information—other than a student or team ID#—is to be included on an entry.
 - b. Exceptions to this rule are:
 - i. Middle school competitive events:
 1. Audio Podcasting (student first name[s] only may be used)
 2. Career Prep
 3. Children's Stories
 4. Community Service Video
 5. Construction Challenge
 6. Structural Engineering

- ii. High school competitive events:
 - 1. Children's Stories
 - 2. Digital Video Production
 - 3. STEM Mass Media
 - 4. Structural Design and Engineering
 - iii. Events that require submission of a Work Log shall include indication of student initials only.
 - c. Unless otherwise noted, for all events that require a display, the size of the display may not exceed 15" deep x 30" wide x 48" high.
11. TSA may choose to keep National TSA Conference student entries.
- a. Such entries may be used by national TSA for promotional purposes. Should that occur, credit for any such entry would be noted by TSA.
 - b. If applicable, the USB flash drive entries become property of TSA and will not be returned.

E. Citations, References, and Copyrighted Material

1. For all applicable competitive events, citations/references must follow a professional citation style of the competitors choosing unless the competitive event specifies a specific formatting style. Failure to use a professional citation style will result in a rules violation of 20% (twenty percent). Some examples of professional citation styles include MLA, APA, Chicago, and IEEE.
2. All entries must be the original work of the student participant or student team.
3. All ideas, text, images (including those labeled "for reuse"), and sound from other sources must be cited.
4. If copyrighted material is used, written permission must be included.
 - a. An Internet search about copyrighted material and copyright fair use is recommended if ideas, text, images, or sound from other sources is incorporated into an event entry.
 - b. Use of the TSA logo is permitted as long as it adheres to the current TSA Branding Guide.
5. Failure to follow any of the above procedures results in a 20% rules violation.

6. Plagiarized content in any event will result in automatic disqualification.

F. Prohibited Materials, References, and Images

1. Hazardous materials, chemicals, lighted or open flames, combustibles, wet cell batteries, and other similar substances are not allowed at the National TSA Conference.
2. No liquids, viruses, live plants, or animals may be used as a part of the display.
3. Competition entries or presentations by participants must not include racial or ethnic slurs/symbols, reference to gang affiliation, or vulgar, violent, subversive, or sexually suggestive language or images.
4. Entries or presentations may not promote products that students may not legally buy, such as tobacco, alcohol, or illegal drugs.
5. Images of guns, knives, or other weapons, or items that can be interpreted as weapons, are prohibited.
6. The Entertainment Software Rating Board (ESRB) provides industry guidance on the content of video games and/or applications. Please refer to the [ESRB overview](#) for the categories, descriptions and elements of video content that may be included in competition entries. Interpretation of the content of competition entries is at the discretion of the judges.

G. TSA Liability

1. TSA is not responsible or liable for any personal property, equipment, competition content, or materials brought to the National TSA Conference for use by a participant or attendee.

H. Event Scheduling Conflicts

1. When an event scheduling conflict could prevent an individual from participating in an event, the individual has the right to not compete in an event.

I. Emergencies

1. Team member substitution may be allowed should a documented emergency arise in team events that involve written and semifinalist segments. All substitutions must be approved by the event manager and coordinator.

J. Event Judging

1. All events are judged in accordance with the stated event criteria as noted in this competitive events guide.
2. Tier scoring has been implemented in the preliminary round of some events and is intended to streamline the evaluation process used to determine semifinalists.
3. The decisions of judges related to competitive events are final.

K. Procedure for filing a grievance with the Rules Interpretation Panel

The Rules Interpretation Panel (RIP), a group made up of at least three (3) CRC members, monitors and oversees the competitive events during the National TSA Conference. The panel provides a means by which state advisors may express grievances and concerns about conference situations that pertain to events, and it ensures continuity from year to year for competitive event rules and regulations.

1. All concerns must be in writing using the correct form in the guide. The Rules Interpretation Panel Grievance form (see 2026 & 2027 Forms Appendix) must be completed in its entirety.
2. Only state advisors may submit a request to the Rules Interpretation Panel (RIP) at the national conference. Should an individual/team/chapter advisor have a concern about an event, the state advisor shall be the point of contact. National TSA will not accept forms from anyone other than the state advisor.
3. During the conference, the RIP panel will meet to discuss and analyze the advisor's concern.
4. It is the intent of the panel to resolve any grievances at the conference with a written response to the state advisor.
5. Only the state advisor may pick up the written response from the RIP panel.
6. All decisions made by the panel are final. There is no appeal process.

L. Rules Violations and Disqualifications

1. Refer to page 38 for information on the TSA Competitive Event Rating Form/Rubric and Go/No Go Specifications.
2. A rules violation that gives a contestant an unfair advantage will result in a twenty percent (20%) deduction of the total possible points in either a preliminary or semifinal round as applicable.
3. The coordinator or manager of an event has the right to disqualify a contestant when this type of incident occurs.
4. The event coordinator and manager must sign off on both a twenty percent (20%) deduction and a disqualification.

M. Semifinalists

1. Should the competition have a semifinal round, the event will have a minimum of twelve (12) semifinalists.
2. Semifinalists (individuals or teams, as applicable) will compete against one another to determine the top ten (10) finalists in an event.
3. All members of a semifinalist team must participate in the semifinalist portion of an event, unless otherwise noted in the event's regulations

N. Electronic Devices

1. Recording devices are not allowed in certain competitive events.
2. CRC manager and event coordinator approval is required before any event may be recorded.
3. All electronic devices, including but not limited to cell phones, iPads/tablets, electronic readers, smart watches, etc., *must* be turned off unless otherwise noted in specific event regulations.
4. No electronic communication devices of any kind are permitted during competition.

COMPETITION REGULATIONS COMMITTEE

The Competition Regulations Committee (CRC) is composed of dedicated STEM teachers and education professionals from across the country who have made major commitments to create and maintain the high quality of national TSA's competitive events. Some CRC members are charged with reviewing TSA's competitive events, updating them as necessary, and presiding over the competitive events at the annual National TSA Conference.

Ideas and feedback regarding events are always welcome. Guidelines and forms can be found in the Forms Appendix of this guide for proposing a new event and for suggesting revisions to existing event.

EVENT COORDINATOR REMINDERS

TSA appreciates the support of its event coordinators, many of whom are teachers attending the conference with students from their chapters. The busy schedules of these individuals prompt the reminders that follow.

- A. Competitive event coordinators must be present for a mandatory event coordinator's meeting on the first day of the conference.
- B. Competitive event coordinators must be present for conference event check-in and check-out if they are coordinating an event in which these activities take place.
 1. Generally speaking, "check-in" is on the evening of registration day, and "check-out" is held on the day before the awards ceremony.
 2. Tentative schedule information will be available before the conference on the [TSA website](#).
- C. The Competition Regulations Committee, which consists of all the event managers, is available throughout the conference to support coordinators as they supervise competitive events.

AWARDS

At the conference awards ceremony, ten (10) finalists in each event are identified in random order and called to the stage for recognition.

EVENT PROPOSAL INFORMATION

As technology evolves and technology education attempts to keep pace and reflect these changes, new TSA events are added, some are revised, and others are dropped. TSA chapter advisors, state advisors, and others are encouraged to submit proposals for new events.

The following topics reflect potential direction for development:

- 21st century technology
- 3D printing
- Adaptive/Assistive Technology
- Artificial Intelligence
- Cloud computing
- CoDrone
- Cyber Robotics Coding
- Data management
- Economic development
- Electronic publishing
- Engineering
- Environmental technology
- Fluid power technology
- Future technologies
- Green technology
- Innovative power sources
- Lasers/satellites/radar
- Manufacturing technology
- Social media marketing
- Transportation technology

When submitting a proposal for consideration, include these elements:

- Overview (description of the event and participant expectations)
- Eligibility for entry
- Limitations (such as time or entry submission requirements)
- Resource considerations (i.e. are the resources a limiting factor, or are they affordable/readily available to all populations? Can this be executed at the national level?)
- Specific regulations
- Required personnel
- Alignment with STEM standards

Formative ideas are welcome, but the more complete the proposal the less likely it will be misinterpreted. The Competition Regulations Committee (CRC) acknowledges all submissions, and each is given consideration for possible inclusion in a competitive events guide. Once submitted, ideas and events become the property of national TSA. Proposals must be submitted by September 1 of the prior conference year in order to be considered for the next guide.

Find the form in the Forms Appendix of this guide. Proposals must include the submitter's name and complete contact information. Proposals may be mailed to CRC, c/o National TSA, 1904 Association Drive, Reston, VA 20191-1540, or emailed in a Word file attachment to general@tsaweb.org.